When the other hostages were released, I checked and found out that she wasn't among them, and I asked the State Department to ask the Algerian and Swiss diplomats to do one more errand for us, suggesting that they hint to the Iranians that the new administration would be much more likely to implement the Carter administration agreement to free Iranian funds held in American banks in exchange for the hostages' release if she was freed first. We never said anything about it publicly. Several days later, she was released.

Long before I ever entered the Oval Office, I had adopted a very simple philosophy regarding the question of what we as a nation should do if an American was held captive abroad against his or her will. I believed that whenever one of our citizens, even the least among us, through no fault of his or her own, was denied the right to life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness, it was up to the rest of us to do everything we could to restore those rights, wherever it took us, anywhere in the world that person was. It was a policy I followed for eight years as president.

During the campaign, I'd been given classified briefings on various problems facing our country internationally, but as president I began to receive much more detailed briefings each morning on the state of the world, and they introduced me to new problems and great opportunities for the country.

I learned the Soviet economy was in even worse shape than I'd realized. I had always believed that, as an economic system, Communism was doomed. Not only was it lacking in the free market incentives that motivated people to work hard and excel—the economic propulsion that had brought such prosperity to America—but history was full of examples showing that any totalitarian state that deprived its people of liberty and freedom of choice was ultimately doomed. The Bolshevik revolution had simply replaced an inherited aristocracy with a self-appointed one, the Soviet leadership,